C1 guide: need, user and design brief

Name _____ Section _____ Date _____

Component 2, Assessment Criterion 1. This is the first page of your coursework folder. It is the page that every later page depends on, so it is worth getting right.

What Cambridge says

These are the examiners' own words, from the Cambridge marking guidance for IGCSE Design and Technology (0445). Read them before you write anything.

- *"Identification of a need or opportunity with an analysis leading to a design brief."*
- *"Candidates should identify a need or opportunity and consider the intended user or user group. Evidence of user consideration can be seen through a record of a conversation/interview with an identified user, or through the results of a questionnaire/survey from which conclusions can be made."*
- *"It may also be useful to consider the type of environment in which the designed product will be used and highlight key issues, photographic evidence could be used here to support written statements."*
- *"As a guide candidate could use 5Ws – Who? What? Why? When? Where?"*
- On how marks are lost: *"Often this area is overmarked because candidates have not identified a user and have failed to carry out any investigation or analysis of the need. On many occasions, it can be seen that a candidate has a preconceived idea of what they want to make."*

What that means for you. You do not start from "I want to make a shelf". You start from a **person** and a **problem**, you find out about them, and the brief comes out of what you found. If your brief could have been written without talking to anyone, it is not finished.

What you hand in

Tick each line when the page is in your folder.

- ☐ **A need or opportunity**, stated about a real person, not in general.
- ☐ **An identified user.** A name or pseudonym, age, where the product lives, two or three problems they face, and **one direct quote**.
- ☐ **Evidence that you consulted them.** Your interview notes, written down in their words, or the results of a short survey **with conclusions** (what the answers tell you).
- ☐ **The environment.** Where will it be used? Write the key issues and add at least one photograph or a measured sketch of the real space.
- ☐ **The 5Ws** filled in (see the example below).
- ☐ **The design brief.** One sentence saying who the user is and what the product is. Then **three or more function points**, each starting "The product must…" and each one testable. Then **one constraint that comes from your user**, beyond the five fixed ones.
- ☐ **A reason for each function point**, linked to something the user said or something you saw.

How to do it, in order

1. **Talk to people, then choose.** Do not pick the product first. Interview at least three people, write only what they actually said, and choose the person whose problem you can solve.
2. **Look at the real place.** Go to where the product will live, photograph it, and measure the space.
3. **Fill in the 5Ws** from what you found, not from what you assumed.
4. **Write the brief** from the 5Ws. Each function point answers one thing the user told you.
5. **Test your own brief.** Hand it to a partner. They circle every function point they could not actually test. Fix those.

The two mistakes Cambridge names

Mistake	How to avoid it
No identified user, no investigation of the need	Your folder must contain the interview or survey, in the user's words.
A preconceived idea of what to make, so the investigation never happens and the brief is a "basic description of the need"	Write the **problem** first. Do not name a product until the 5Ws are done.

A worked example (invented, for a different product)

This example is made up so you can see the standard. Your own user and product must be your own.

W	Answer
Who	Marta, 34, a hospital nurse who works night shifts and shares a room with her partner.
What	A place to put her phone, her glasses and a book where she can find them in the dark.
Why	She knocks things off the bedside table and has to switch on the main light, which wakes him.
When	Every day before and after her shift, in low light.
Where	The wall side of her bed, in a gap 350 mm wide and 300 mm deep (photographed and measured).

Direct quote: "I can never find my glasses without turning the big light on."

Brief: "A wall-side bedside shelf for Marta, a night-shift nurse, that lets her find her glasses, phone and book in the dark without waking her partner."

Function point	Why (from the user)
The product must hold a phone, a glasses case and two paperbacks (about 1.2 kg) without tipping.	The things she keeps on her table now.
The product must have a switch she can find by touch with one hand.	She cannot see the table in the dark.
The product must give enough light to find the glasses without lighting the room.	Her partner is asleep.

Constraint from the user: it must fit inside the 350 mm gap beside the bed.

Check before you hand it in

- Could someone who has never met your user say, from your pages alone, what they need? yes / no
- Is there a direct quote from your user anywhere? yes / no
- Is there at least one photograph or measured sketch of the real place? yes / no
- Could you test every function point with a ruler, a weight or a stopwatch? yes / no